

NEWS • ⌚ 3 minute read

Only 10% of Nigeria's working-age population uses generative AI – report



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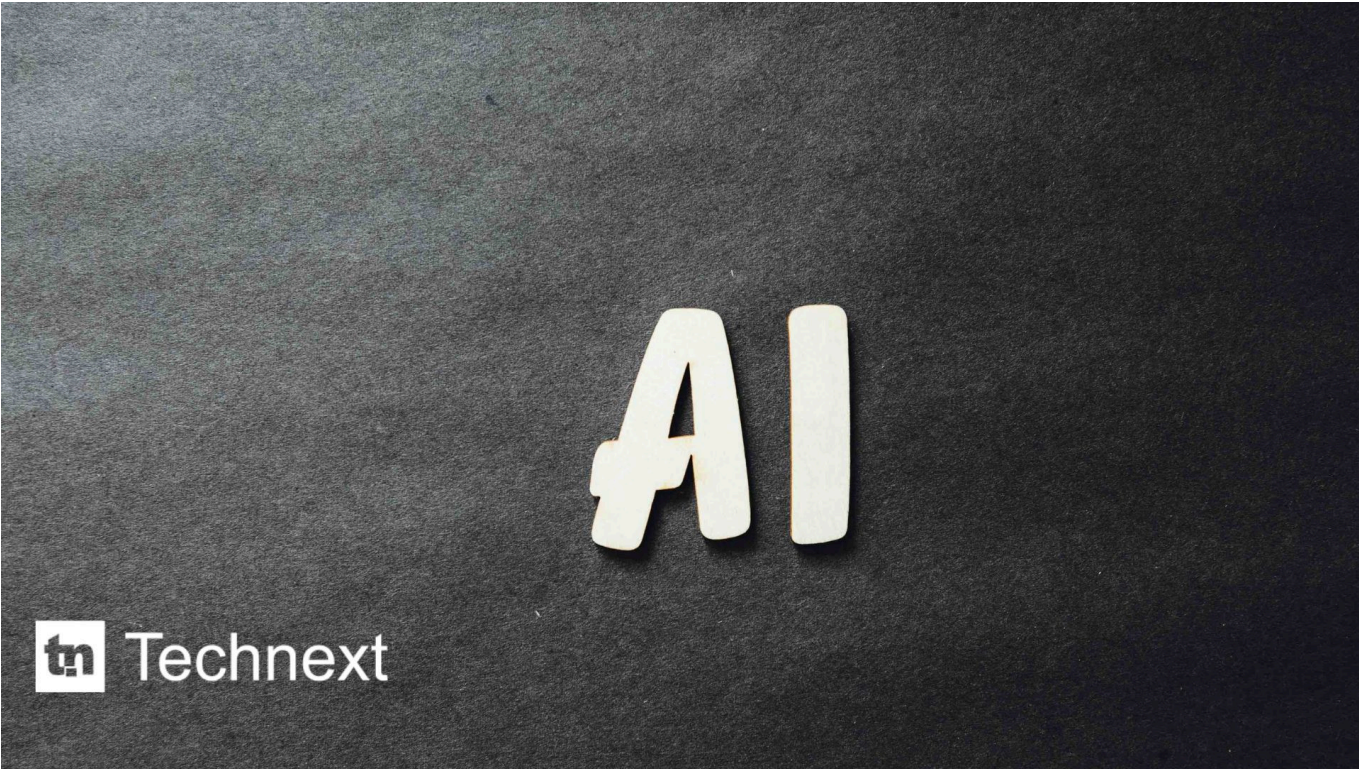
New da



shows South Africa has become the clear
of continental rivals like Nigeria and

The report, **'Global AI Diffusion Q1 2026'**, tracked the use of generative AI across 147 countries and found a widening digital divide across the continent.

The report revealed that South Africa ranked first in the region and 46th globally with 23.1% of the working-age population actively using a generative AI product in the first quarter of 2026.



Artificial Intelligence adoption in Africa

This figure is a clear outlier from the rest of the continent and positions the country as the only African country in the club of mid-tier economies in the world in terms of AI adoption.

Conversely, the data for other leading African tech hubs presents a sobering reality. Nigeria, the continent's largest economy by GDP and home to a vibrant, digitally engaged, youthful population, was a distant fourth with just 10.1%, less than half the South African figure. Kenya did even worse, trailing at 8.7%. The picture in much of sub-Saharan Africa remains grim, with countries like Uganda and Ethiopia reporting adoption rates well below the 8% level.

Micro



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the risk of exclusion

transitioned from an experimental novelty into core infrastructure, it is actively reshaping hiring practices, boosting productivity, and

defining economic competitiveness in ways that will only compound over the coming years. For African nations lagging in adoption today, the long-term economic costs could be dire.

Microsoft's [report](#) places Africa's figures within a broader, unforgiving global context. The upper echelons of the diffusion index are dominated by high-income economies characterised by established digital ecosystems, robust broadband penetration, and substantial enterprise investment in AI tooling.

The concentration of African nations near the bottom of the table exposes a convergence of structural barriers that analysts have long warned about, but which this quantified data now makes undeniably concrete.



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AI Diffusion Data Source

Economy	H1 2025	H2 2025	Q1 2026	Q1 Change
United Arab Emirates	59.4%	64.0%	70.1%	6.1%
Singapore	58.6%	60.9%	63.4%	2.5%
Norway	45.3%	46.4%	48.6%	2.2%
Ireland	41.7%	44.6%	48.4%	3.8%
France	40.9%	44.0%	47.8%	3.8%
Spain	39.7%	41.8%	44.2%	2.4%
New Zealand	37.6%	40.5%	43.0%	2.5%
United Kingdom	36.4%	38.9%	42.2%	3.3%
Netherlands	36.3%	38.9%	42.1%	3.2%
Qatar	35.7%	38.3%	41.8%	3.5%
Australia	34.5%	36.9%	39.5%	2.6%
Belgium	33.5%	36.0%	39.0%	3.0%
Israel	33.9%	36.1%	38.1%	2.0%
Switzerland	32.4%	34.8%	37.8%	3.0%
Canada	33.5%	35.0%	37.3%	2.3%
South Korea	25.9%	30.7%	37.1%	6.4%
Sweden	31.2%	33.3%	36.1%	2.8%
Austria	29.1%	31.4%	34.1%	2.7%
Hungary	27.9%	29.8%	32.2%	2.4%
Taiwan	26.4%	28.4%	31.8%	3.4%
United States	26.3%	28.3%	31.3%	3.0%
Denmark	26.6%	28.7%	31.2%	2.5%
Germany	26.5%	28.6%	31.1%	2.5%
Poland	26.4%	28.5%	31.0%	2.5%
Italy	25.8%	27.8%	30.3%	2.4%

Economy	H1 2025	H2 2025	Q1 2026	Q1 Change
Colombia	20.4%	22.0%	24.5%	2.5%
Lithuania	21.0%	22.4%	24.3%	1.9%
Serbia	19.7%	21.5%	24.1%	2.6%
Jamaica	22.2%	22.1%	24.0%	1.9%
Panama	20.3%	21.5%	23.3%	1.8%
South Africa	19.3%	21.1%	23.1%	2.0%
Chile	19.6%	20.8%	22.7%	1.9%
Japan	16.7%	19.1%	22.5%	3.4%
Bosnia And Herzegovina	18.2%	19.5%	22.1%	2.6%
Argentina	17.8%	19.6%	21.9%	2.3%
Malaysia	18.3%	19.7%	21.8%	2.1%
Kuwait	17.7%	19.1%	21.1%	2.0%
Greece	17.7%	19.1%	20.8%	1.7%
Georgia	17.3%	18.2%	20.5%	2.3%
Mexico	16.7%	17.8%	20.1%	2.3%
Philippines	17.1%	18.3%	20.1%	1.8%
Ecuador	17.0%	17.7%	19.5%	1.8%
Brazil	15.6%	17.1%	19.1%	2.0%
Albania	15.8%	16.5%	18.5%	2.0%
Moldova	16.6%	17.0%	18.5%	1.5%
El Salvador	14.6%	16.2%	18.3%	2.1%
Azerbaijan	14.2%	15.5%	17.7%	2.2%
India	14.2%	15.7%	17.6%	1.9%
Romania	15.3%	16.2%	17.5%	1.3%
Turkey	13.4%	14.6%	17.4%	2.8%
Mongolia	12.6%	14.3%	16.7%	2.4%
Guatemala	13.7%	14.8%	16.4%	1.6%
Peru	13.4%	14.7%	16.4%	1.7%
China	15.4%	16.3%	16.4%	0.1%
Kazakhstan	12.7%	13.7%	15.9%	2.2%
Namibia	13.0%	13.8%	15.1%	1.3%
Gabon				
Libya				
Egypt				
Botswana				
Nepal				
Indonesia				
Honduras				
Senegal				

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Economy	H1 2025	H2 2025	Q1 2026	Q1 Change
Algeria	11.3%	12.0%	13.2%	1.2%
Zambia	11.7%	12.3%	13.1%	0.8%
Cote D'Ivoire	10.8%	11.7%	13.1%	1.4%
Bolivia	10.9%	11.6%	12.7%	1.1%
Iran	9.6%	10.7%	12.6%	1.9%
Iraq	10.3%	11.2%	12.5%	1.3%
Thailand	9.1%	10.7%	12.4%	1.7%
Paraguay	10.1%	11.0%	12.2%	1.2%
Nicaragua	10.0%	10.7%	11.8%	1.1%
Morocco	10.5%	10.9%	11.7%	0.8%
Gambia	10.6%	10.9%	11.4%	0.5%
Pakistan	9.7%	10.3%	11.4%	1.1%
Angola	8.9%	9.7%	10.9%	1.2%
Madagascar	8.9%	9.7%	10.9%	1.2%
Malawi	8.9%	9.7%	10.9%	1.2%
Mozambique	8.9%	9.7%	10.9%	1.2%
French Guiana	8.3%	9.0%	10.3%	1.3%
Guyana	8.3%	9.0%	10.3%	1.3%
Suriname	8.3%	9.0%	10.3%	1.3%
Venezuela	8.3%	9.0%	10.3%	1.3%
Benin	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Burkina Faso	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Ghana	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Guinea	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Guinea-Bissau	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Liberia	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Mali	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Mauritania	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Niger	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Nigeria	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Sierra Leone	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Yemen	8.7%	9.3%	10.1%	0.8%
Marshall Islands	8.4%	9.1%	10.0%	0.9%
Timor-Leste	8.8%	9.1%	9.8%	0.7%
Myanmar	7.6%	8.4%	9.6%	1.2%
Tajikistan	7.6%	8.2%	9.5%	1.3%
Laos	7.6%	8.0%	9.5%	1.5%
Maldives	9.1%	9.0%	9.4%	0.4%

AI Index

infrastructure. But reliable and affordable broadband access is extremely fragmented across sub-Saharan Africa. Generative AI tools in the cloud require stable high-speed internet connections.

Otherwise, the entry barrier remains prohibitively high for millions of potential users. And while smartphone adoption is accelerating across the continent, it still lags far behind that of the world's leading AI economies, which constricts the mobile-first pathways through which emerging markets typically adopt new technologies.

Economic realities add to the complication. More sophisticated consumer AI tools and business software are priced for Western markets. Where the affordability of products is significantly eroded by purchasing power parity, there are structural headwinds that even enthusiasm for technology may not be able to overcome in terms of uptake.

Education and baseline awareness complete the restrictive triad. Generative AI literacy is unevenly distributed. Within the continent, this literacy tends to remain siloed in major urban centres and among knowledge workers who already possess exposure to advanced digital workflows.

South Africa's relative success is attributed to simultaneous advantages across these dimensions: higher broadband penetration, a larger formal knowledge economy, and greater corporate investment in digital transformation.



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Africa is not included, he argued.

nce
Lubanzadio, OpenAI's Africa lead,
said, "AI cannot benefit all of humanity if

He warned that the exclusion of the continent from the generative AI revolution would severely undermine the core mission of these transformative technologies. Underscoring the necessity of bridging this technological gap to ensure equitable progress.

Microsoft's Q1 2026 data is a stark warning to African governments and private sector leaders to deliberate on how best to invest in tech and innovations.

The generative AI adoption gap between South Africa and the rest of the continent is not going to self-correct; it requires coordinated action on tech literacy, software affordability, and digital infrastructure, else, today's AI divide could become a lasting economic deficit.



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Health Lab

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Tage-Trick gegen
Nagelpilz (Genial)**



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Digital PayExpo 2026 to Convene Africa's Most Influential Payments Leaders

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Africa's digital payments ecosystem will take centre stage as [Digital PayExpo 2026](#) returns to Lagos on June 17–18, 2026, at the Landmark Centre, Victoria Island, under the theme:

"Seamless Digital: Fostering Pan-African Market Expansion in the AI Era."

At a time when artificial intelligence, cross-border commerce, and financial inclusion are redefining Africa's economic future, the event is set to convene over 3,000 senior executives, policymakers, fintech innovators, and global technology providers.

The speaker lineup reflects a powerful blend of regulatory leadership, private sector innovation, and pan-African expertise.

Read also: [The Hub: inside Ibukun Awosika's workspace with a \\$1,500 membership plan](#)

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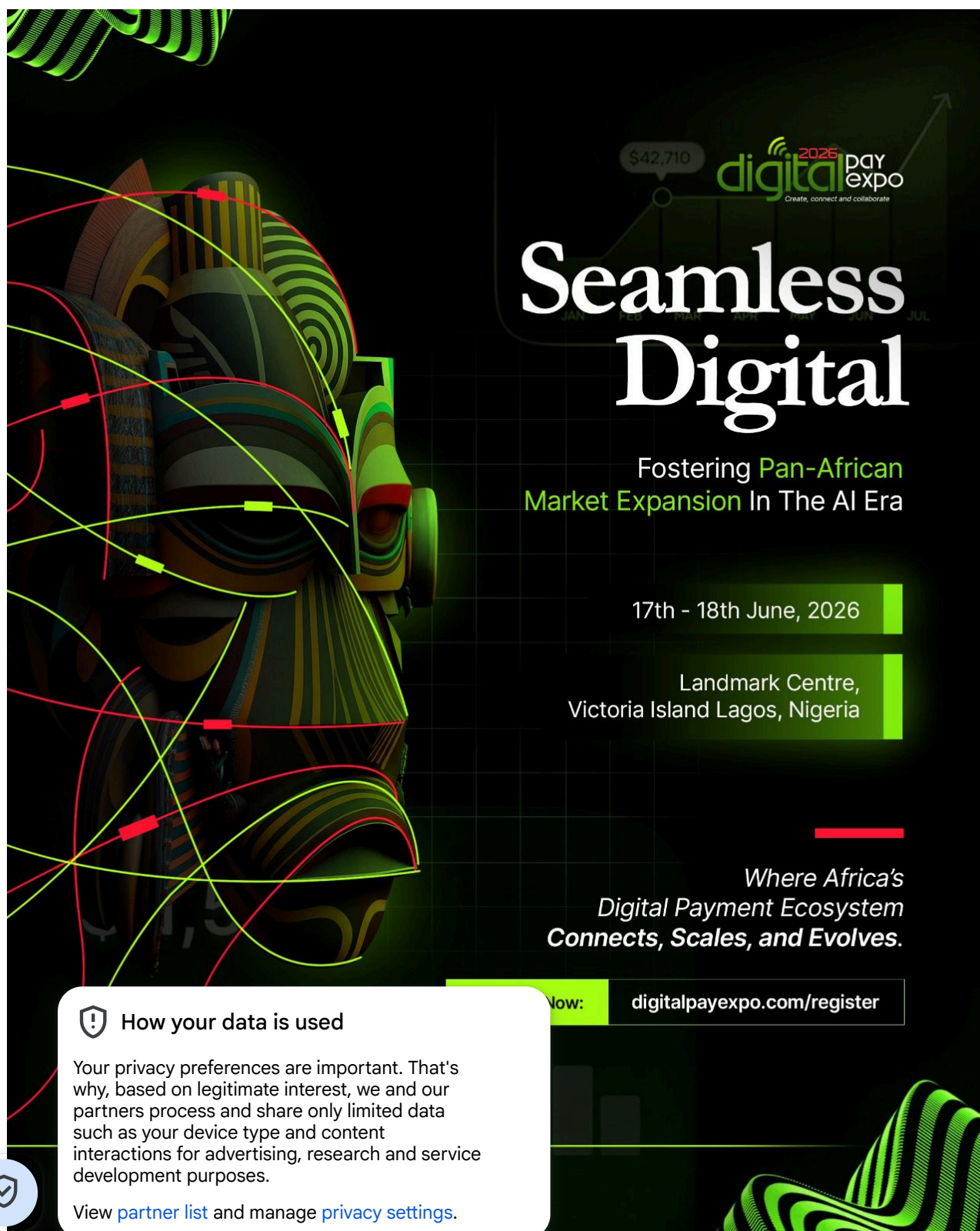
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Supervision, Central Bank of Nigeria — a

Area Business Head (West Africa),

Mastercard — a leading voice in digital payments expansion across Africa.

- **Clara B. Arthur**, Managing Director, GhIPSS (Ghana) — driving Ghana's interoperable payment ecosystem.
- **Wacera Maina**, Chief Operations Officer, Kenwitch Kenya — an expert in East Africa's payment infrastructure evolution.
- **Akeem Lawal**, CEO, Interswitch Group — a pioneer in Africa's fintech growth story.
- **Ngover Ihymembe-Nwankwo**, Executive Director, NIBSS — shaping Nigeria's core payment infrastructure.



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The conference will explore:

- AI-powered financial services
- Cross-border payment systems and interoperability
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- SME financing and financial inclusion
- Infrastructure for a unified African digital economy

With participation from banks, fintechs, telcos, regulators, and global payment networks, Digital PayExpo 2026 is positioned as a critical marketplace for ideas, partnerships, and investment flows.

Register: <https://digitalpayexpo.com/register>

Sponsorship Enquiries: oyin@intermarc-ng.com



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